

EXPERIMENT NO: 3

EMERGING TRENDS IN LOW-CODE DEVELOPMENT

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Key Trends, Platform Categories, and a Head-to-Head Comparison of Leading Low-Code Platforms

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Table of Contents

1. Executive Summary
2. Introduction
3. Market Overview and Growth Trajectory
4. Trend 1: The Fusion of Generative AI and Low-Code
5. Trend 2: The Continued Rise of Citizen Development
6. Trend 3: Enterprise Security, Governance, and Compliance
7. Types of Low-Code Platforms
8. Platform Comparison: Leading Low-Code Platforms
9. Challenges and Risk Considerations
10. Key Takeaways for Decision-Makers
11. Future Outlook and Conclusion
12. Appendix: Glossary of Key Terms
13. Master Comparison Table: Final Platform Analysis
14. Sources Consulted

1. Executive Summary

Low-code development has moved from a niche productivity tool to a foundational layer of enterprise software delivery. Analyst estimates converge on the same broad conclusion: by 2026, a substantial majority of new enterprise applications are being built with low-code or no-code technologies, with market forecasts placing the global low-code platform market in the range of roughly USD 40 to 49 billion in 2026, on a trajectory toward several hundred billion dollars by the mid-2030s.

This report surveys the trends reshaping the low-code landscape in 2026 and, in its second half, compares the leading platforms organizations are actually choosing between. The single most transformative trend is the fusion of generative and agentic artificial intelligence with visual development. Alongside this, the report examines the continued rise of citizen development and the intensifying demand for enterprise-grade security and governance. It then categorizes the platform landscape into five broad types and profiles ten of the most widely evaluated platforms side by side, closing with a master comparison table intended as a quick-reference decision aid.

The report also addresses the risks that accompany rapid low-code and AI-agent adoption, including new categories of shadow IT and shadow AI, and closes with practical takeaways for decision-makers choosing or renewing a low-code strategy.

2. Introduction

Low-code development platforms (LCDPs) allow individuals to design, build, and deploy applications using visual interfaces, pre-built components, and configuration rather than hand-written code. No-code platforms extend this idea further, removing the need for any coding at all. Together, these platforms have become central to how organizations respond to a persistent shortage of professional software developers, growing backlogs of internal IT requests, and pressure to digitize processes faster than traditional development cycles allow.

The purpose of this survey is twofold: first, to consolidate the most significant and well-supported trends currently shaping the low-code market, and second, to give buyers a structured, side-by-side comparison of the platforms competing for their attention. The report draws on recent industry analysis, market research, and vendor and analyst commentary published through mid-2026.

2.1 Scope and Methodology

This survey synthesizes publicly available market research, analyst commentary, and industry reporting current as of mid-2026. Figures cited from multiple sources sometimes vary because different research firms use different definitions of the low-code and no-code market, different geographic scopes, and different forecast horizons. Where estimates diverge, this report presents the range rather than a single definitive figure. Platform pricing is likewise presented as commonly reported starting figures; actual costs vary by region, contract negotiation, and add-ons.

3. Market Overview and Growth Trajectory

The low-code market has sustained double-digit compound annual growth for several consecutive years, and multiple analyst firms now treat low-code as core enterprise infrastructure rather than an emerging or experimental category. Gartner's frequently cited projection is that by 2026, roughly 70 to 75 percent of new enterprise applications will be built using low-code or no-code technologies, up from under 25 percent only a few years earlier.

Market sizing estimates vary by research firm, but the overall direction is consistent: strong current-year revenue in the tens of billions of dollars, compounding at an annual growth rate in the high-teens-to-30-percent range, heading toward a market worth several hundred billion dollars within the next decade.

Metric	Reported Figure
2026 market size estimate	Approximately USD 44.5B–48.9B (varies by source)
Projected market size (2029–2034)	USD 58.2B by 2029; USD 376.9B by 2034 (upper-bound forecasts)
Compound annual growth rate	Approximately 19–29% depending on scope and horizon
Share of new enterprise apps built on low-code/no-code	Approximately 70–75% by 2026 (Gartner)
Enterprise developers already using low-code in some form	Approximately 87% (Forrester)
Low-code users originating outside formal IT	Approximately 80%, up from 60% in 2021

Table 1. Representative low-code market statistics reported by analyst and industry sources, 2026.

Adoption is not evenly distributed across industries or regions. Financial services reports some of the highest adoption rates, driven by regulatory compliance automation and demand for customer-facing digital tools, while healthcare is frequently cited as the fastest-growing vertical. IT and telecom continue to represent the largest single share of global low-code revenue, North America leads by total revenue, and Asia-Pacific is frequently identified as the fastest-growing region.

4. Trend 1: The Fusion of Generative AI and Low-Code

The most consequential shift in the low-code market is the integration of generative and agentic AI directly into the development experience. Rather than treating AI as a bolt-on feature, leading platforms now position large language models as the primary engine behind application creation: describing an application, workflow, or data model in natural language and having the platform generate a working draft that a builder then refines visually.

4.1 From Visual Assembly to Prompt-Driven Creation

Industry commentary frames this as a shift comparable in scale to the transition from static HTML pages to interactive, JavaScript-driven web applications: low-code tools are moving from static, pre-defined interfaces toward dynamic applications generated and adapted in response to user prompts. AI copilots embedded in low-code platforms increasingly assist with generating data schemas, business logic, test cases, and documentation alongside the visual application itself.

4.2 AI Agents as a New Application Category

A related and fast-growing phenomenon is the use of low-code and no-code tools to build autonomous AI agents that take action inside enterprise systems rather than simply generating text. Analyst projections suggest that a large share of enterprise applications will embed AI agents by the end of 2026, a sharp increase from a small fraction only a year earlier. Surveys of large enterprises report that a majority already have active AI agents built with low-code or no-code tools embedded in sales, finance, customer service, and product workflows.

Metric	Reported Figure
Low-code platforms with integrated AI features	Approximately 72%
Enterprise applications projected to embed AI agents by end of 2026	Approximately 40%, up from under 5% in 2025

Metric	Reported Figure
New application code predicted to be AI-generated by 2028	Approximately 45% (via no-code/low-code interfaces)
Fortune 500 companies using active AI agents built with low-code/no-code tools	More than 80%
Of those, organizations with a clear agent management strategy	Roughly 10%

Table 2. Reported penetration of AI and agentic capability within low-code platforms, 2026.

The gap between the top rows and the last row of Table 2, widespread deployment against a comparatively small share of organizations with a clear management strategy, is one of the clearest warning signs in the current market and is discussed further in Section 9.

5. Trend 2: The Continued Rise of Citizen Development

Citizen development, in which employees without formal software engineering backgrounds build their own applications and automations, continues to expand as a share of overall low-code usage. Estimates suggest that around 80 percent of low-code users now sit outside formal IT departments, a substantial increase from roughly 60 percent five years earlier.

Several forces are driving this trend: a persistent shortage of professional developers, sustained IT project backlogs that leave business units waiting for support, and low-code tooling that has become mature and intuitive enough for non-specialists to use safely for departmental-scale problems.

5.1 Fusion Teams and the Changing Role of IT

A related organizational trend is the growth of so-called fusion teams, in which a professional developer, a business analyst, and a subject-matter expert collaborate directly within a low-code platform rather than passing requirements back and forth between departments. This is shifting the role of central IT away from being the sole builder of applications and toward providing guardrails, shared components, and platform governance for a much larger population of builders.

Metric	Reported Figure
Employees outside IT who customize or build solutions	Approximately 41%
Custom enterprise apps built by employees outside IT	Approximately 60%
Those built by users with limited or no coding skills	Approximately 30%
Enterprises adopting low-code to reduce IT backlogs	Approximately 84%
IT leaders reporting they are blocked from strategic work by backlogs	Approximately 72%

Table 3. Citizen development and IT-backlog statistics, 2026.

6. Trend 3: Enterprise Security, Governance, and Compliance

As low-code and no-code tools move from departmental experiments to systems that touch core business processes and regulated data, security and governance have become defining purchasing criteria rather than afterthoughts. IT leaders in 2026 report prioritizing platforms with role-based access controls, automated compliance checks, and built-in data encryption, particularly in regulated industries such as healthcare, financial services, and the public sector, where platforms must demonstrate alignment with frameworks such as GDPR, HIPAA, and PCI-DSS.

6.1 Shadow IT and the New Category of Shadow AI

The democratization of application development carries a well-documented downside: ungoverned citizen-built applications, sometimes called shadow IT, can accumulate as undocumented technical debt that central IT does not know exists. A newer and more complex variant, often called shadow AI, has emerged as employees and business units deploy AI-powered agents and low-code AI tools without central approval. Because these agents can act autonomously, chaining actions across multiple connected systems without a human reviewing each step, they are frequently described as a qualitatively different risk category from traditional shadow IT.

6.2 Common Concerns Reported by Enterprise Leaders

- Shadow IT risk from ungoverned citizen development
- Long-term application scalability as low-code systems grow in scope
- Vendor lock-in tied to proprietary platform ecosystems
- Application security, particularly around data access and integration sprawl
- Limited suitability of some platforms for highly complex, mission-critical applications

7. Types of Low-Code Platforms

Not all low-code platforms serve the same purpose, and treating the category as a single, undifferentiated market is a common buying mistake. Industry sources generally converge on five broad platform types, distinguished by their target builder, deployment model, and the complexity of application they are designed to support.

Platform Type	Representative Platforms	Primary Use Case
Enterprise Application Platforms	OutSystems, Mendix	Large, complex, mission-critical applications built by professional developers with full DevOps lifecycle support
Business Process / Workflow Automation Platforms	Appian, Pega, ServiceNow App Engine	Case management, business process management, and orchestration-heavy applications
Ecosystem-Integrated Platforms	Microsoft Power Apps, Salesforce Platform	Applications that extend an organization's existing SaaS ecosystem (Microsoft 365/Azure, Salesforce)
Citizen Developer / SMB App Builders	Zoho Creator, Google AppSheet, Bubble	Accessible, fast application creation for business users and small teams with a low technical bar
Open-Source Internal Tool Builders	ToolJet, Appsmith, Budibase (with Retool as a leading proprietary alternative)	Developer-oriented internal tools and dashboards, often self-hosted for data sovereignty

Table 4. Five broad categories of low-code platforms and their representative vendors.

8. Platform Comparison: Leading Low-Code Platforms

This section profiles ten of the most widely evaluated low-code platforms in 2026, organized by the categories introduced in Section 7. Each profile summarizes what the platform is best known for, its typical buyer, and its general pricing posture; a consolidated master comparison appears in Section 13.

8.1 OutSystems

OutSystems is positioned as an enterprise-grade platform built for large, complex, and highly scalable applications, with strong DevOps and full application lifecycle tooling. It supports cloud, on-premises, or hybrid deployment and was ranked the top development software platform on G2's 2026 list by developer satisfaction. Pricing is customized rather than published, and industry commentary notes that custom-priced enterprise platforms can run five to ten times the cost of simpler tools for comparable capability.

8.2 Mendix

Mendix emphasizes collaborative, model-driven development with strong support for microservices and cloud-native architecture, and is frequently recommended for organizations with significant SAP investments. It publishes a free tier alongside custom-priced paid tiers and is generally considered to have a moderate learning curve, positioned between the accessibility of Power Apps and the technical depth of OutSystems.

8.3 Microsoft Power Apps

Power Apps is part of the Microsoft Power Platform and is widely regarded as the easiest of the enterprise-grade tools to start with, thanks to deep integration with Dataverse, SharePoint, Teams, and Power Automate. It reports tens of millions of users across Microsoft 365 and typically starts around USD 20 per user per month, making it a natural default for organizations already standardized on Microsoft infrastructure.

8.4 Appian

Appian specializes in process-centric applications, combining low-code development with business process management and robotic process automation in a single platform, and offers a free community edition for learning. Typical enterprise pricing is reported around USD 90 per user per month, reflecting its positioning toward complex workflow and case-management use cases rather than simple departmental apps.

8.5 Salesforce Platform

Salesforce Platform extends the Salesforce CRM ecosystem into custom low-code application development, and is the natural choice for organizations already standardized on Salesforce. Reported pricing spans roughly USD 25 to 100 per user per month depending on tier, reflecting a wide range of capability from simple extensions to sophisticated custom applications.

8.6 Zoho Creator

Zoho Creator is positioned as an SMB-friendly citizen-developer platform that can automatically generate native iOS and Android applications alongside its web app output. At roughly USD 8 per user per month, it is one of the more budget-friendly options among platforms capable of producing genuinely cross-platform mobile applications.

8.7 Bubble

Bubble is a no-code web application builder commonly recommended for startups and teams building customer-facing web products without an engineering team, rather than for internal enterprise systems. It is frequently grouped alongside Webflow as a leading choice specifically for web application use cases.

8.8 Retool

Retool is a proprietary internal-tool builder with the largest reported market share in that category, known for a large component library, broad integrations, and recently expanded mobile app support. It is not self-hostable on its lower tiers, and its usage-based, per-active-user pricing model is frequently cited as a cost concern once deployments scale into dozens of builders.

8.9 ToolJet

ToolJet is an open-source, self-hostable low-code platform aimed at internal tools and enterprise workflows, with built-in AI application generation, broad data-source connectivity, and no per-end-user licensing fee. It is frequently recommended for teams that want enterprise-grade governance features, such as SSO and audit logs, without the cost structure of fully proprietary platforms.

8.10 Appsmith

Appsmith is an open-source internal-tool builder similar in positioning to ToolJet, offering a free self-hosted tier with unlimited users and usage-based pricing for its managed cloud offering. It is commonly evaluated alongside ToolJet and Budibase by teams specifically seeking open-source licensing and data-sovereignty guarantees.

9. Challenges and Risk Considerations

The trends and platforms surveyed above point to substantial upside, but industry sources are consistent in flagging real risks that organizations must actively manage rather than assume away.

9.1 Governance Maturity Lags Adoption Speed

Multiple 2026 reports note a significant gap between how quickly organizations are deploying low-code applications and AI agents, and how mature their governance of those systems actually is. Surveys report that a large majority of large enterprises already have active AI agents in production, while only a small minority have a clear strategy for managing them.

9.2 Technical Debt and Loss of a Single Source of Truth

Applications built quickly at the departmental level can become long-term maintenance burdens once the original builder moves on, particularly when there is no central record of what was built, why, or how it connects to other systems.

9.3 Regulatory Attention Is Increasing

Regulatory and standards bodies are beginning to respond directly to the growth of agentic and low-code-built AI systems, including new agent-focused standards initiatives and enforcement timelines tied to broader AI regulation.

9.4 Skills and Change Management

As building software becomes accessible to a much wider population of employees, organizations need new skills and processes that did not previously exist inside most business units, including basic data-modeling literacy and awareness of when a departmental tool has grown complex enough that it should be handed off to professional IT ownership.

Enterprise Concern	Share of Leaders Citing It
Scalability of citizen-built apps	47%
Vendor lock-in	37%
Application security	25%
Shadow IT risk from ungoverned development	61%
Limited capability for complex applications	32%

Table 5. Leading enterprise concerns about low-code adoption, 2025–2026.

10. Key Takeaways for Decision-Makers

The trends and platform comparisons in this report point to a consistent set of practical implications for technology and business leaders.

- Treat AI-assisted and agentic capability as a core evaluation criterion when selecting or renewing low-code platforms, not an optional add-on.
- Match the platform category to the job: enterprise application platforms for mission-critical systems, process platforms for workflow-heavy use cases, ecosystem platforms where you are already standardized, and open-source builders where cost control and data sovereignty matter most.
- Build a single, current inventory of every low-code application and AI agent in production, including who owns it and what systems it can access.
- Apply least-privilege access to AI agents in the same way it is applied to human accounts, with explicit approval gates for high-impact actions.
- Favor platforms with genuine DevOps integration (version control, testing, CI/CD) over those that treat low-code as an isolated island.
- In regulated industries, confirm compliance alignment (for example GDPR, HIPAA, PCI-DSS) directly with vendors rather than assuming it.
- Shift from periodic, point-in-time compliance reviews toward continuous, automated monitoring of what low-code applications and agents are doing in live environments.

11. Future Outlook and Conclusion

Looking ahead, the trends surveyed in this report suggest that low-code development will continue converging with mainstream software engineering practice rather than remaining a separate, lightweight alternative to it. AI will keep moving from an assistive feature toward the primary interface for creating and modifying applications, and the distinction between no-code, low-code, and traditional development will keep narrowing into a single, layered development continuum.

At the same time, the organizations that benefit most from this shift are likely to be those that pair rapid adoption with equally serious investment in governance, and that choose platforms deliberately by matching platform type to the job at hand rather than defaulting to whichever vendor is best known. Low-code's central promise, faster delivery with less specialized engineering effort, is genuine and increasingly well documented across industries; realizing that promise sustainably will depend on treating both governance and platform selection as first-class strategic decisions.

12. Appendix: Glossary of Key Terms

- Low-code development platform (LCDP): A tool that lets builders create applications primarily through visual configuration, with the option to add custom code where needed.
- No-code platform: A tool that lets builders create applications entirely through visual configuration, without writing code.
- Citizen developer: An employee without a formal software engineering role who builds applications or automations using low-code or no-code tools.
- Fusion team: A cross-functional group combining professional developers, business analysts, and subject-matter experts working together within a shared low-code platform.
- AI agent: A software component that can autonomously take multi-step actions across connected systems in pursuit of a goal, as distinct from a chatbot that only generates a response for a human to review.
- Shadow IT: Technology, including applications, used within an organization without formal approval, visibility, or support from central IT.
- Shadow AI: A newer variant of shadow IT specific to AI tools and agents deployed or used without central approval, oversight, or an audit trail.
- Vendor lock-in: The difficulty or cost of moving an application, its data, or its logic off a given platform once it has been built there.

13. Master Comparison Table: Final Platform Analysis

The table below consolidates the platform profiles from Section 8 into a single reference. It is intended as a starting shortlist, not a final scoring system; the right platform still depends on an organization's existing technology stack, in-house technical skill, and governance requirements.

Platform	Category	Best Fit	Deployment	Typical Pricing	Key Strength	Key Limitation
OutSystems	Enterprise Application	Large, complex, mission-critical apps	Cloud / on-prem / hybrid	Custom (premium)	DevOps depth, scalability, developer satisfaction	High cost, steeper learning curve
Mendix	Enterprise Application	Collaborative, hybrid, SAP-integrated apps	Cloud / on-prem / hybrid	Free tier + custom paid tiers	Model-driven collaboration, SAP integration	Custom pricing at scale can be costly
Microsoft Power Apps	Ecosystem-Integrated	Microsoft 365 / Azure-centric business apps	Cloud (Microsoft)	~\$20/user/month	Ease of use, deep Microsoft integration	Less suited outside Microsoft ecosystem
Appian	Process / Workflow Automation	BPM, case management, RPA-heavy apps	Cloud / on-prem	~\$90/user/month; free community edition	Strong process orchestration and automation	Higher cost, process-first not general-purpose
Salesforce Platform	Ecosystem-Integrated	Salesforce-centric custom apps	Cloud (Salesforce)	~\$25–\$100/user/month	Deep CRM/ecosystem integration	Best value only if already on Salesforce
Zoho Creator	Citizen Developer / SMB	SMB apps with native mobile output	Cloud	~\$8/user/month	Low cost, auto-generated native mobile apps	Lighter enterprise governance than top-tier tools
Bubble	Citizen Developer / SMB	Customer-facing web apps, startups	Cloud	Tiered SaaS pricing	Fast web app creation without code	Not designed for internal enterprise systems
Retool	Open-Source-Adjacent Internal Tools	Developer-built internal tools, dashboards	Cloud (limited self-host on higher tiers)	~\$10–\$12/builder/month + end users	Largest internal-tools market share, mobile support	Cost scales quickly; not fully self-hostable on lower tiers

Platform	Category	Best Fit	Deployment	Typical Pricing	Key Strength	Key Limitation
ToolJet	Open-Source Internal Tools	Self-hosted internal tools, secure workflows	Cloud or self-hosted	Free tier; ~\$24/builder + \$8/end user (Business)	No per-end-user fee, built-in AI generation, Python support	Smaller ecosystem than legacy enterprise vendors
Appsmith	Open-Source Internal Tools	Self-hosted internal tools, budget-conscious teams	Cloud or self-hosted	Free self-hosted; usage-based cloud (~\$0.40/hr)	Free unlimited-user self-hosting	Advanced governance features reserved for paid tiers

Table 6. Master comparison of ten leading low-code platforms across category, fit, deployment, pricing, strengths, and limitations.

Read together with Table 4's category framework, this master table is designed to support a two-step shortlisting process: first narrow to a platform category based on the primary use case, then compare the two or three platforms within that category against the specific weighting an organization places on cost, deployment control, and ecosystem fit.

14. Sources Consulted

This report draws on publicly available industry research and analyst commentary published through mid-2026, including reporting and statistics from Gartner, Forrester, IDC, and G2, together with industry and product analysis published by ToolJet, Kissflow, Hostinger, VTI, CMARIX, GenCodex, Evonsys, Security Boulevard, Vectra AI, CIO.com, ITECS, ArmorCode, Aona AI, NareshIT, OutSystems, Gartner Peer Insights, Ngenious Solutions, GEM Corporation, CatDoes, Softr, Vybe, WeWeb, Appsmith, and Technorucs. Figures reflect the estimates reported by these sources as of their publication dates and should be treated as directional rather than precise, given definitional and methodological differences across research firms.